Africa and established trading posts and refuelling points. Imagine their indignation when Spain backed a maverick called Columbus who sailed west, based on patchy and erroneous data, and made one of the greatest discoveries of history. Incensed, they lobbied with the Pope to divide the world into Spanish and Portuguese spheres of influence. As per the Treaty of Tordesillas 1494, Spain was awarded a claim to all lands west of a meridian of longitude 370 leagues west of the Cape Verde islands. All lands discovered to the east of the line belonged to Portugal.

When it soon became clear that Columbus had not found a westward route to India, the Portuguese must have heaved a sigh of relief. They knew from an earlier voyage led by Bartholomeu Dias that Africa could be rounded. A new expedition was prepared in 1497 under Vasco da Gama. It comprised of three ships—the flagship *San Gabriel*, the smaller *San Rafael* and the traditional caravel *Barrio*.[6] An unarmed supply-ship also accompanied them part of the way. Note that these ships would have been quite small and unsophisticated compared to those of Admiral Zheng He, but the Chinese had already withdrawn into an inward-looking shell and were no threat to the Portuguese.

The fleet set sail on 8 July 1497 and rounded the Cape of Good Hope by November. After this point Vasco was in uncharted waters. As they sailed up the Mozambique coast, the Portuguese began to encounter Arabic-speaking people. Vasco must have been very pleased to see this because it proved that he was indeed in the Indian Ocean. The Arabs had long established slaving ports along this coast and some of them had grown into sizeable habitations. However, no one in this world expected to come upon a European fleet. Indeed, it appears that the Arabs initially thought that these fair-skinned foreigners were Turks. The Portuguese had the advantage of having several Arabic speakers amongst them as the Iberian peninsula had only recently been liberated from Moorish rule. Thus, they were able to converse with the locals and pretend to be fellow-Muslims. When asked by a local sheikh for his copy of the Koran, Vasco lied that he had left it behind in his homeland near Turkey.[7]